Simon Aquino

Engineering Manager · Head of Platform · Cloud-Native Architect (GCP/AWS/Azure)

London, United Kingdom (open to relocation)

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Executive Profile

Hands-on Engineering Leader with 15+ years of experience building and scaling high-performance teams in AI-driven and data-intensive environments. Combines deep architectural expertise in Cloud-Native systems (GCP/AWS, Kubernetes) and secure, event-driven architectures with a proven track record of growing engineering units from seed to enterprise scale. A "builder-leader" who thrives on solving complex technical challenges—from regulatory compliance to distributed orchestration—while fostering cultures of ownership and engineering excellence.

- **Organisational Growth:** Extensive experience defining hiring strategies and scaling engineering organisations (from 3 to 50+), managing the full employee lifecycle to build high-trust, autonomous teams.
- **Technical Strategy:** Expert in bridging the gap between business goals and technical execution, designing scalable, event-driven architectures (Kubernetes, Go) and "Golden Path" platforms that transform Developer Experience (DevEx) and product velocity.
- **Operational Excellence:** Dedicated to raising the bar on engineering standards, embedding security/compliance (GDPR, ISO, SOX, NIST), and driving continuous improvement in CI/CD, observability, and system resilience.
- **Stakeholder Management:** Skilled in navigating complex multi-stakeholder environments, translating architectural needs into commercial value, and managing multi-million pound budgets to align technical roadmaps with company strategy.

Professional Experience

Barclays (Payments Incubator)
London, UK

Principal Platform Consultant (Contract) — *Oct. 2025 - Present*

- **Greenfield Strategy:** Architecting the Internal Developer Platform (IDP) for the Payments division, leveraging AWS and Kubernetes to modernise DevEx and critical processing rails for high-throughput payments.
- **Organisational Transformation:** Leading the technical transformation of a software unit into Cloud-Native Platform Engineers, accelerating adoption through hands-on pair programming and coaching the internal Tech Lead on platform strategy and team enablement.
- **Strategic Governance:** Acting as the Technical Authority for the incubator, defining 'Golden Path' architecture patterns and automated compliance frameworks to transition legacy systems into a secure, self-service ecosystem.

JPMorgan Chase / Core Engineering Consulting Group
London, UK

Engineering Manager, Accelerator Platform — *Apr. 2023 - Sep. 2025*

- **Scaling High-Performance Teams:** Scaled the Cloud Enablement unit from 3 to 50+ engineers, owning the full employee lifecycle (hiring, performance management, retention) to build a diverse, high-trust engineering culture focused on delivery excellence.
- **Enterprise-Scale Infrastructure:** Architected the firm-wide GCP foundation and Kubernetes ecosystem (100+ clusters), creating repeatable blueprints and automated control implementations (aligned to NIST) to enable the secure delivery of mission-critical, data-intensive workloads.
- **Strategic Alignment:** Partnered with C-suite executives to align technical roadmaps with business goals, translating architectural decisions into commercial value and managing a multi-million pound vendor budget.
- **Operational Excellence:** Championed a Platform-as-a-Product mindset, introducing Crossplane and GitOps to significantly improve Developer Experience (DevEx), system observability (Prometheus/Grafana), and platform reliability.

Deloitte
Copenhagen, Denmark

Infrastructure DevOps Lead - AWS — *Mar. 2021 - Mar. 2023*

- **Multi-Vendor Leadership:** Led the cloud infrastructure stream for Denmark's critical Property Tax Platform, orchestrating 3 satellite teams to drive delivery autonomy and resolve cross-functional architectural blockers.
- **Strategic Cost Optimisation:** Executed a high-impact infrastructure consolidation strategy, simplifying legacy complexity to reduce monthly cloud operational costs without compromising system performance.
- **Modernisation & Security:** Eliminated high-risk technical debt by replacing brittle custom authentication with managed AWS API Gateway, establishing a standardised, secure pattern for external integrations.

Microsoft
London, UK

Principal Consultant - Azure — *Nov. 2020 - Mar. 2021*

- **High-Frequency Trading Acceleration:** Rescued a stalled on-prem to Azure migration for a major trading platform, optimising AKS and EventHubs architectures to handle massive throughput and condense the delivery timeline from years to months.
- **Strategic Enablement:** Delivered the first fully automated development environment, acting as the technical bridge between client business units and Microsoft Product Engineering.

Loveholidays *London, UK*

Lead Platform Engineer - GCP *Mar. 2020 - Oct. 2020*

- **Performance Engineering:** Diagnosed and resolved critical latency bottlenecks in the core search engine, profiling Go/Java microservices to optimise Kubernetes autoscaling and achieve a 30% performance increase.
- **Event-Driven Architecture:** Designed and developed a custom Go library for real-time database synchronisation via GCS, reducing data propagation latency from minutes to seconds to improve customer search accuracy.

eBay *Berlin, Germany*

Lead DevOps Engineer - GCP *Jun. 2019 - Mar. 2020*

- **Global Cloud Transformation:** Orchestrated the strategic migration of eBay's Classifieds vertical to Google Cloud (GCP), architecting standardised GKE workflows to enable rapid deployment for distributed engineering teams across Europe.

Previous Engagements (Select Highlights) *Europe*

Senior DevOps Engineer / Consultant *2010 - 2019*

- **Deloitte (Copenhagen):** Architected immutable AWS infrastructure for critical Danish Tax systems, introducing IaC to reduce deployment frequency from weeks to hours.
- **Element Insurance (Berlin):** Built the greenfield AWS/Kubernetes foundation for a high-growth FinTech startup, serving as Interim Team Lead to scale early engineering capability.
- **HMRC (London):** Core WebOps Engineer for the UK's hyper-scale digital tax platform; contributed to open-source tooling to ensure multi-cloud resilience during peak filing windows.
- **Google (London/Dublin):** Developed Python/App Engine automation tools to optimise internal engineering workflows, awarded multiple peer bonuses for code quality and innovation.

Skills

Leadership & Strategy	Engineering Strategy, Tech Recruitment, Team Scaling (3-50+), Remote/Distributed Leadership, Performance Management, Executive Stakeholder Management, Vendor Strategy, Budgeting, FinOps.
Cloud & Platform	GCP (Pro Architect), AWS, Azure, Kubernetes (K8s), Internal Developer Platforms (IDP), Developer Experience (DevEx),Platform-as-a-Product, Terraform/Hashicorp, Crossplane, ArgoCD, Flux, Helm, Istio.
Architecture & Dev	Go, Python, Ruby, Bash, C, Java Spring Boot, Event-Driven Architecture, Distributed Systems, Microservices, API Design (gRPC/REST), Domain-Driven Design (DDD).
Ops, Security & Data	Prometheus, Grafana, Datadog, DevSecOps, Zero Trust, ISO27001/SOC2 Controls, AI/ML Infrastructure Readiness, SRE Practices.

Education

University of Bristol *Bristol, UK*

Master of Engineering (MEng) Hons in Computer Science and Electronics *2012*

Languages

English	C2 - Native / Bilingual Proficiency
Italian	C2 - Native / Bilingual Proficiency
German	B2 - Professional Working Proficiency
Danish	A2 - Elementary Proficiency

Certificates

2025	**Google Cloud Platform (GCP),** Professional Cloud Architect (PCA)
2025	**Google Cloud Platform (GCP),** Generative AI Leader
2015	**Scrum Alliance,** Certified ScrumMaster (CSM)
2014	**UK Government,** UK Security Clearance (SC) [Previous]
2014	**Red Hat,** Red Hat Certified System Administrator (RHCSA)
2013	**VMware,** Certified Advanced Professional 5 - Data Centre Admin (VCAP5-DCA)
2013	**VMware,** Certified Professional 5 - Data Centre Virtualisation (VCP5-DV)
2011	**Google,** Python Readability (Internal Code Quality Award)